

The National Fire Ant Eradication Program's National Management Group (NMG) held its second meeting this month.

NMG members were provided with an extensive overview of the work being done to deliver on the National Fire Ant Eradication Program (NFAEP) Work Plan 2023–24. It discussed the eradication treatment being conducted in parts of the Gold Coast, Scenic Rim, Southern Downs and Lockyer Valley, and the preparations underway to start in Somerset and Moreton Bay. Eradication treatment is expected to start in the northern section of the NFAEP's eradication area next month. This work will be completed by a new group of field staff based in the new Caboolture depot.

The recent success of the NFAEP's drone trial was discussed, and members noted that treatment by drones will be operationalised next month. This work will be conducted on a range of land types across the eradication treatment area.

NMG members also approved the NFAEP's response plans for fire ant detections in Murwillumbah and Wardell, New South Wales (NSW). Tracing investigations indicated that both detections were likely a result of human-assisted movement.

The extended period of poor weather had also resulted in some delays in eradication treatment. The NFAEP continues to work closely with the NSW Department of Primary Industries and the relevant councils to increase awareness of fire ants and the need for community to consent to eradication activities being conducted on their properties. Eradication activities will comprise treatment and/or surveillance of all targeted properties up to five kilometres from each detection. This will need to be completed multiple times over two years before proof of freedom can be declared.

The NMG will next meet in May 2024. During this meeting the NMG will consider expert technical advice received from its newly established NFAEP Consultative Committee.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/rifa-28-mar-2024>